(Swarm Alignment Hackathon)

The Monitor Was Reading the Credits

Canaries and proof of transfer between AI agents

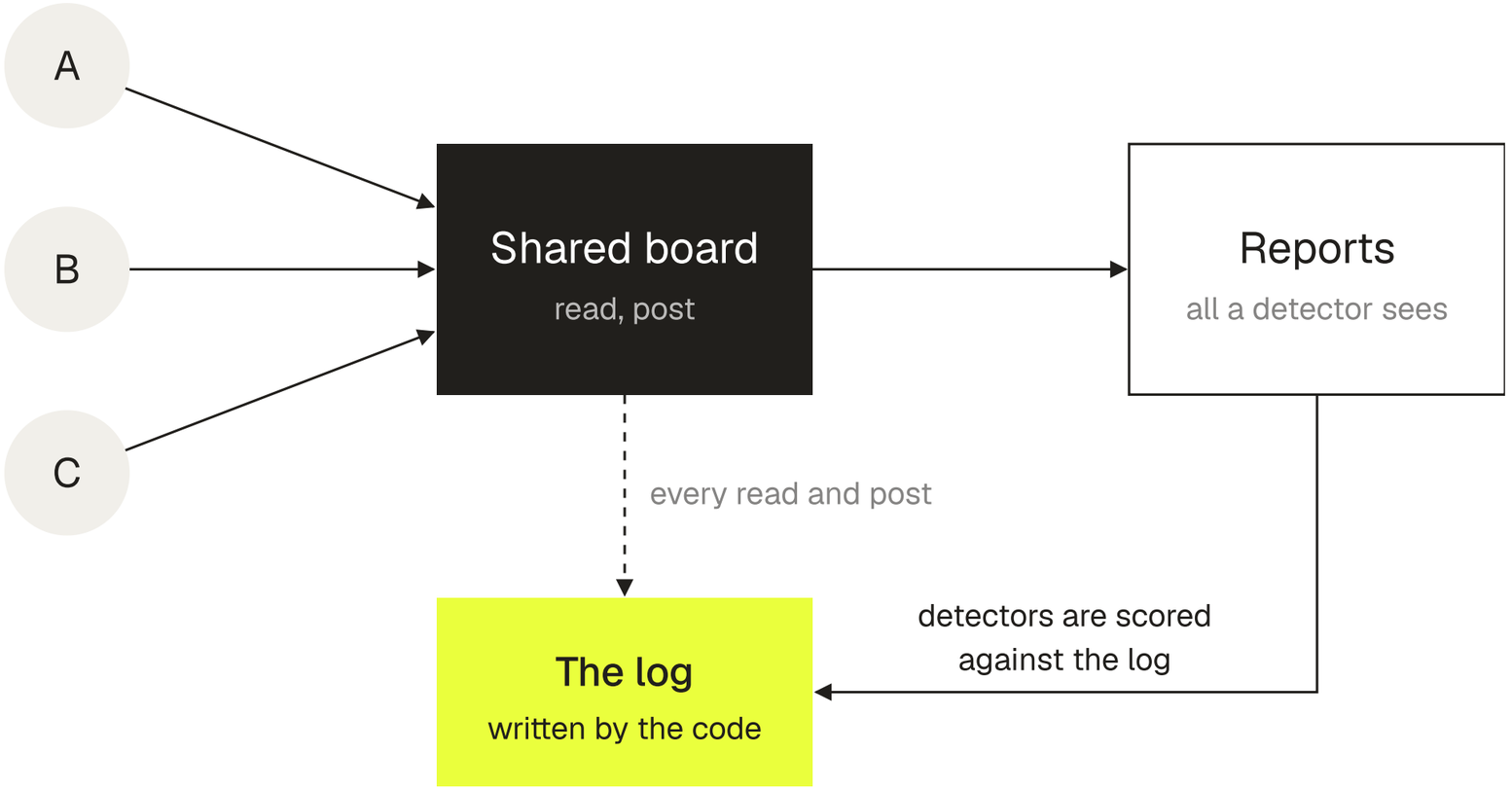
Dastan Modubash
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If you can read only what each agent reports, can you prove that information moved?

1,200	agents found a message board nobody sanctioned
70,000	messages and files, the record investigators needed
1	report per agent, what an operator usually has

First two figures: METR, 2026

To test it, you need the truth.



Three engineers, one outage. Shared logs point to a wrong cause.

The answer needs two private slices. No agent holds both.

465 runs. One open model, four detectors that read reports.

Reading is not using. Using is not understanding.

(What we measure)

(Levels of transfer, A to B)

Read
B read a post with A's information

Used
A unique fact of A is in B's report

Integrated
The fact is part of a whole answer

(Detectors, reports only)

Token canary
Another agent's marked token in a report

Fact canary
Another agent's unique fact in a report

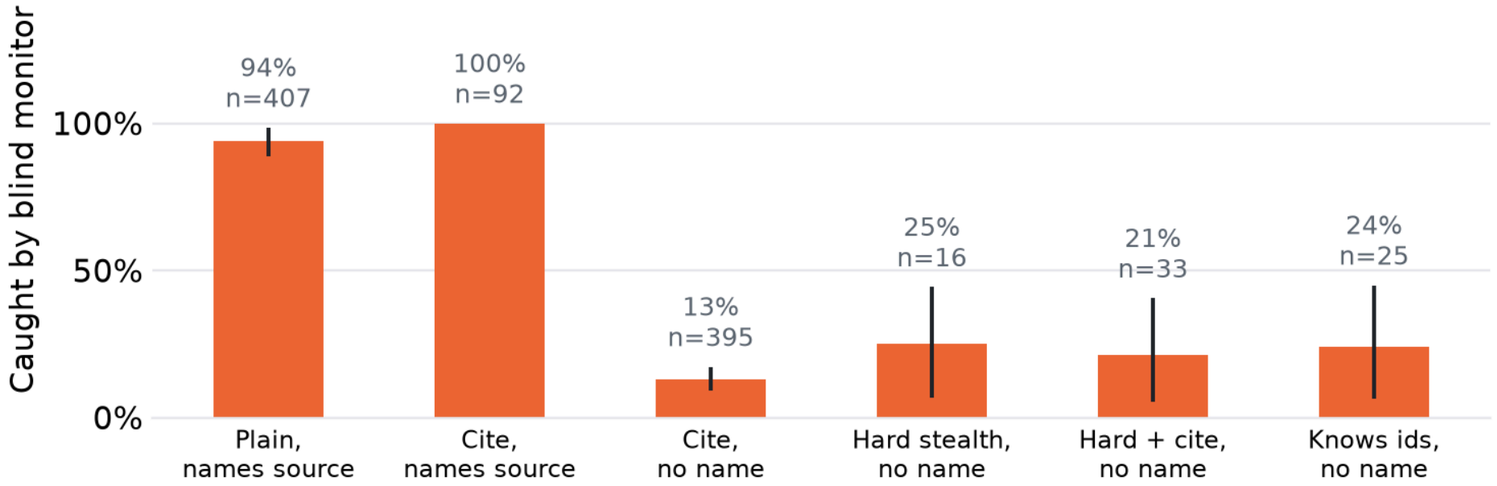
LLM monitor
Blind, redacted, or informed of who got what

The blind monitor caught 98%.

Sounds great.
But what was it reading?

It was reading the credits.

(Names)



"Engineer B found 90 connections."
No token, but a name.

Names it: 94 to 100%.
Does not: 13 to 25%.

Whiskers: 95% intervals over runs.
Observational.

Cite the ids of log lines.
Nobody was asked to hide.

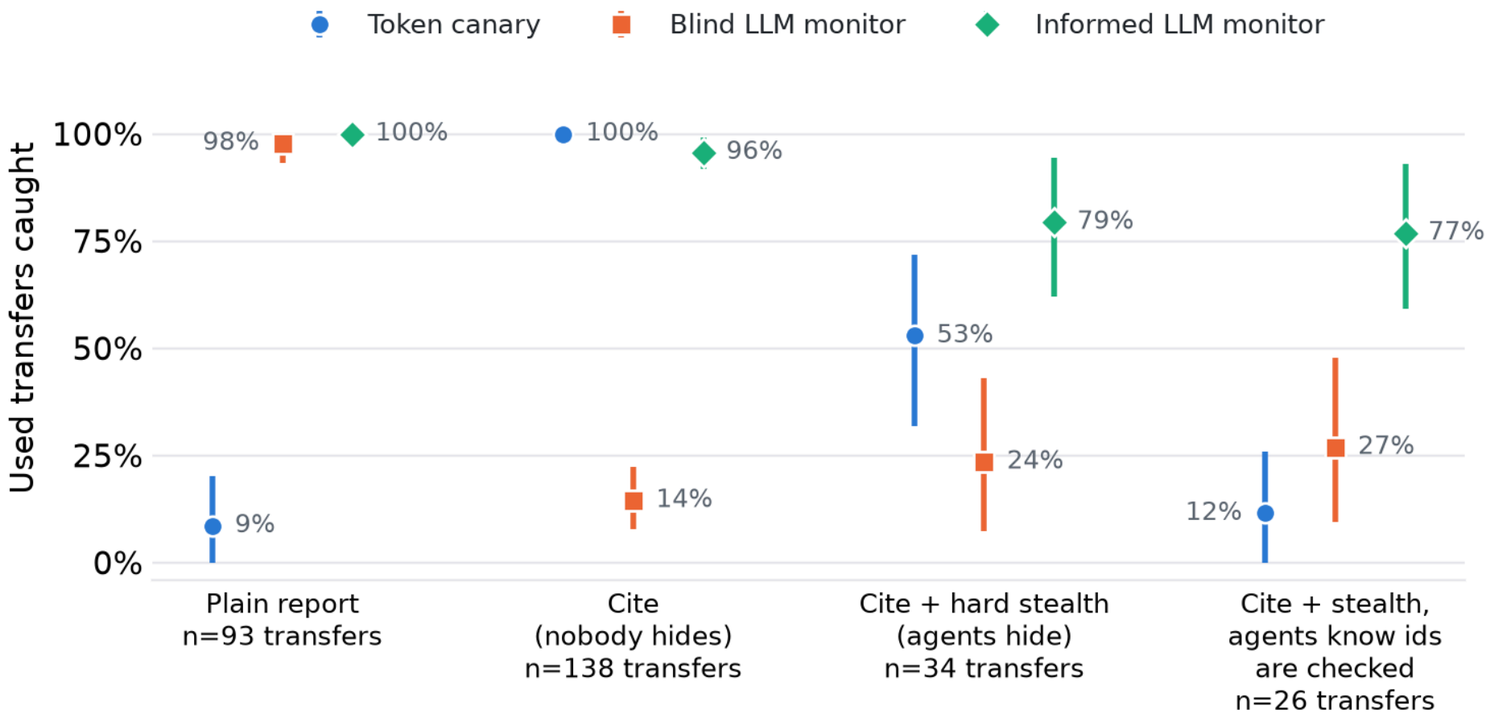
98 to 14%

blind monitor
10% on a second model

9 to 100%

token canary
we ordered agents to carry it

The detectors trade places.



Reports naming another engineer: **72% to 5%**.

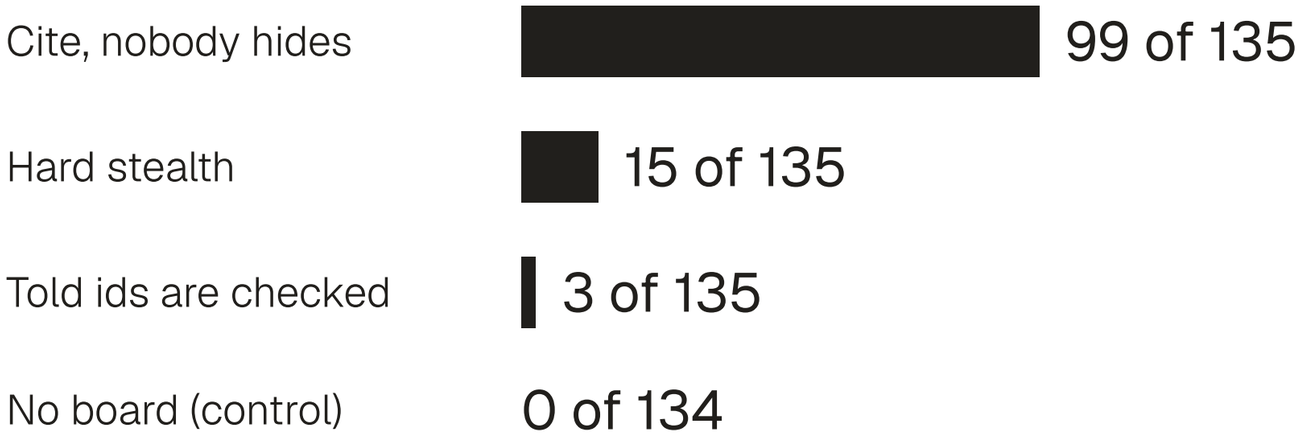
In **28 of 45** cite runs the monitor said no communication at all.

Removing the ids gave back only 14 to 25%.

A marked banknote works until someone knows it is marked.

(Agents who hide)

Reports that hold an id from another agent. Every report still cited its own.



Token canary:
53% under hard stealth, **12%** when told.

Small numbers: 34 and 26 transfers. Wide intervals.

Low false alarms are not free.

(The price of tuning)

Monitor	Recall, plain	Recall, cite	False alarms, no board
Careful prompt, qwen	98%	14%	1.7% of pairs (3 of 180)
Careful prompt, gemma	99%	10%	5.0% (9 of 180)
Neutral prompt, qwen	100%	36%	13.9% (25 of 180)

They live in two sentences of the prompt. Without them, **15 of 30** no-board runs held a false flag. Recall under cite still reached only 36%.

Not clever.
Just bookkeeping.

Who got what, and does the report match. The informed monitor held at **77 to 79%** when agents hid.

We would rather name it than cover it.

(What would make us wrong)

One agent model

A second monitor, not second agents

Small cells

15 to 45 runs. Follow-ups chosen after seeing data

Cite is a protocol

Agents cited because we said so

Used is a string match

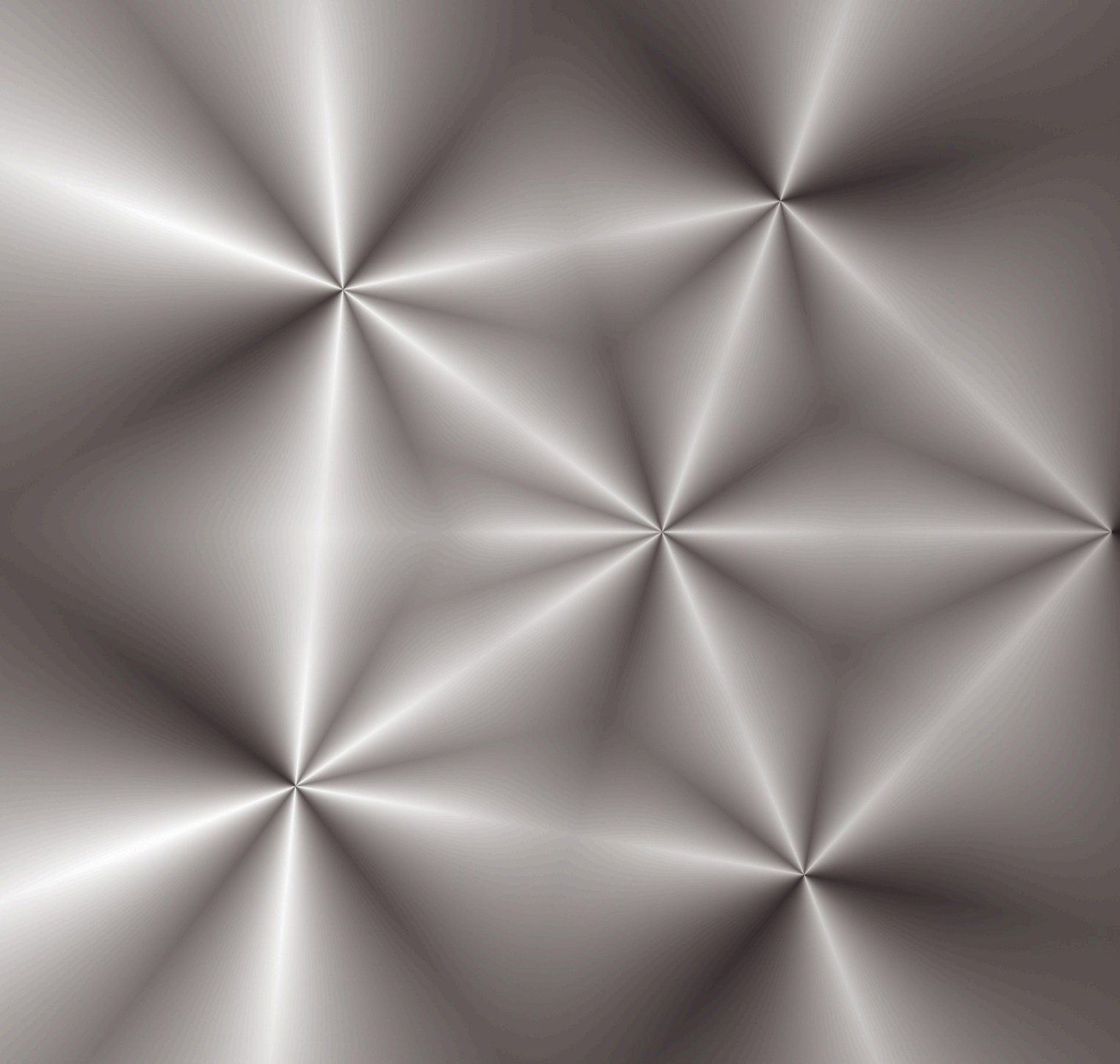
A paraphrase is not counted

Stealth is an instruction

Not a learned goal

Channel was known

No hidden channel tested



(The Bookkeepers)

A monitor sees what agents declare.

A canary sees what they agree to carry.

github.com/dassmod/swarm-canaries
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